This is a Public Service Announcement

By Laurie Notaro

I hate public bathrooms.

I love and respect the sanctity of my own home potty; it may be as dirty as a truck stop, but at least I know the filth is mine, and I am free to do as I please or need. The fear of having to use a public bathroom is so horrible that I will do just about anything to avoid it.

INTRODUCTION

Snicker if you will, but the International Paruresis Association, or IPA, estimates that the fear using a public restroom affects an estimated 17 million Americans, or 7 percent of the population. Think about it: You can avoid spiders or heights or flying and many other sources of common fears. But hydrating the body and releasing toxins is essential to life. And the fear, in part, is due to all of you who AREN'T afraid of the public restroom . . . in fact it's because some of you are just too dang comfortable in there! So . . . especially for all you women out there . . . This is a Public Service Announcement by Laurie Notaro.

4NG Fanatics

When I was in sixth grade, my mother made me sign up for Girl Scout camp, and when I got there, I knew I was in for a long haul. The only way the facilities remotely qualified for the term "rest room" was because there was a light switch and a swinging bare bulb; other than that luxury, it was an outhouse, a long stream of port-o-potties lined in a row that smelled like the 4-H exhibit at the state fair on a hot day. The acoustics were incredible, and nearly echoed. What choice did I have? I held it for nearly two weeks and probably should have been hospitalized when I got home, but the pain that shot through my body when my intestines finally seized was nothing compared to the shame of pushing out a plopper within earshot of fifty Girl Scouts.

Even as an adult, I've noticed that some people don't play by the rules and terrorize other people in the potty. I have therefore documented several bathroom terrorists that have tormented me and countless other potty hostages, forcing us to hold it in for unnatural periods of time. If you see yourself in any of the

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

descriptions [you are about to hear], seek help. Cease your awful behavior before I am forced to do it for you.

Because I will.

The Trespasser: This violator is no friendly neighbor. She seeks pleasure by invading audio and aroma space of an already occupied unit by ignoring the "One-Stall Cushion" rule. She blatantly chooses the one next to it, despite groups of other available units within the vicinity. This action will automatically cease the operations being conducted in the already occupied stall, causing health risks and alarm. From a personal perspective, I can tell you that I try to use my turn-on/shut-off valve as little as possible so I don't wear it out and become incontinent by my next birthday, because they don't have transplants for those, you know. Try this catchphrase to remind you: "Beware of Fart, Stay One Apart."

The Hoverer: Perhaps to avoid using a time-consuming potty protector, perhaps to mark her territory, this offender won't let her bottom touch the seat, although it's perfectly OK if her by-products do.

4NG Fanatics

Now, the target area of a bowl is rather generous, so the reasons for a misfire are rather mysterious to me, unless the participant is completely standing up and aiming from a corner. Hovering is never, NEVER acceptable behavior unless you just dug a hole in the forest. Remember this the next time you're tempted to resist a complete landing: "Don't Leave Your Mark, Just Sit Down and Park."

The Talker: Easily identifiable as the office chatterbox, the powers of this malefactor increase in strength once you are trapped in the same room and you're half naked. Starting off with something as innocuous as "How are you?" the Talker persists in conversation until your gastrointestinal system has recoiled and everyone else in the bathroom has discovered that your mom is a lesbian, your husband has left you, and there's a wart on your left hand. Words of caution: SILENCIO! Once the door closes on that stall, I am a nameless entity. IF I am at work, I do not exist as Laurie your co-worker, Laurie in the car pool, or the Girl That Everyone Hates. I am simply the Anonymous

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Pee-er. Do not attempt to make conversation with me. Do not ask me questions, and especially do not say, "BOY! Indian food again, huh?" When considering opening your mouth, let this come to mind: "Hear Me Unzip, Button Your Lip!"

The Waiter: Pity the Waiter. Unlike the others on this list, the Waiter is no criminal, sadly just a victim. Typically the Waiter has urgent emergencies at hand, yet is too polite and thoughtful to shoot off a missile while others are present. The Waiter is often in pain, clutching her abdomen in order to keep her organs from exploding. She is minutes away from death. Unfortunately, many don't recognize the symptoms of a Wiater and hang around the bathroom like it was a free-sample booth at Costco. If you suspect there is a Waiter in your presence, leave immediately. If you are a Waiter yourself and sense that you are engaged in something of a Mexican standoff with another Waiter, call a truce, count to three, courtesy flush for background noise, then release. Offer to exit first, but only with the promise that the rival Waiter will not

4NG Fanatics

emerge until you have cleared the premises, lest you see each other's face. Don't forget now: "Silence, No Doubt; Just Get the Hell Out."

The Primper: If the Waiter has a mortal enemy, it is the Primper. I hate the Primper. HATE THE PRIMPER! If there's a horrifying sound a Waiter never wants to hear, it's the THUMP of a purse on the counter. Then the digging sound of the Primper's claws trying to find makeup, hairbrushes, and perfume. You see, I feel that if you cannot complete your prep work by the time you leave your house in the morning, you have completely forfeited your right to do so at any other point in the day. Your opportunity is over and you have lost your chance. Once, I was stuck in a bathroom waiting for a Primper to leave while my intestines threatened to shoot out of my belly button for hours. By the time the ordeal was over, it was dark outside, and everyone in my office thought I had gone home. SO the next time you plop that feed bag next to the sink, recall: "Face of a Gnome? Do Your Makeup at Home!"

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

So all you Trespassers, Hoverers, Talkers, and Primpers, beware. I'm waiting for you, ready to pounce from inside my favorite stall. And just because I haven't seen your face, it doesn't mean a thing.

I know your shoes.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Laurie Notaro
Book: The Idiot Girls' Action-Adventure Club
ISBN: 978-0375760914
Publisher: Villard Books
Date (Month/Year): July 2002

AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY